51. Building Your Persistent Linux Lab

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Phase: Phase 0 — Orientation
Estimated time: 1–2 days
Slug: `51-lab-vm-practice`

Learning objectives

- Create a disposable VM snapshot workflow
- Document lab IP/users
- Separate 'break glass' practice VMs
- Automate lab provisioning lightly

Prerequisites

Complete prior numbered lessons. Prefer a real Linux VM/container for Linux-specific topics.

Your lab should let you:

- Snapshot before dangerous lessons (disks, boot, firewall)
- Reset quickly
- Take notes of what broke

Suggested: Ubuntu LTS VM + second Alpine container host for contrast.

Common mistakes

- Practicing firewall on the only machine you own without console
- No snapshots
- Mixing prod credentials into lab

Exercises

Work in `exercises/51-lab-vm-practice/`. Run:

```
./test.sh
```

- **A (Drill):** make `./test.sh` pass
- **B (Apply):** note one real command you ran on a Linux host related to this lesson
- **C (Challenge):** rewrite your solution from memory the next day

Do not open `solutions/51-lab-vm-practice/` until you have an honest failing attempt.

Self-check

1. Why snapshots?
2. What two distros to compare?
3. Prod creds in lab risk?

Further reading

- https://ubuntu.com/download/server